“Is the Help Actually Happening?” Eight Questions Families Ask About the Care a Parent Is Getting

General answers in plain words, and who to ask when the question is about Dad himself.

Plenty of families have looked at a care schedule and wondered how much of it is really happening. These are the questions that come up at that point, with plain answers.

The answers are general. They aren't about Dad himself, and where a question needs someone who knows him, the note under the answer says who that is.

1 How do we work out which of Dad's needs aren't being met?

Start by setting needs and help side by side, one need at a time. The Administration for Community Living's lists are a plain vocabulary for the needs: basic personal tasks such as bathing, dressing and eating, and everyday tasks such as meals, housework, shopping and taking medication. For each one on Dad's list, write who covers it and how you know. The lines with nobody beside them, or with only a guess, are the ones to ask about. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can see who helps with something but can't tell whether the help is enough. Whether help is adequate is a judgment for the people who assess him.

2 The visit is on the schedule. Doesn't that mean it's happening?

It means it was arranged. A schedule or a care plan says what is supposed to happen; it isn't a record of what did. For a Medicare-certified home health agency, Medicare describes the plan of care as listing what services are needed, who should give them, and when and how often. Mark each line “seen” or “scheduled,” and ask about the scheduled ones. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like to know which visits were made. Ask the agency's office what record it keeps of visits and what it can tell the family.

3 We think something was missed. Does that mean the care has failed?

No. Right now it's something you haven't confirmed, and that is different from something that went wrong. Write it as a question: what was expected, which day, and who would know. Then ask, the way the National Institute on Aging suggests raising any worry, without sounding critical. Until you have an answer, the line stays under “not sure yet.” [3] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've asked and the answer still doesn't match what you saw. Where the help comes from a Medicare-certified home health agency, Medicare's booklet says to talk to both his provider and the home health team if you feel needs aren't being met.

4 What do we actually know, and what still needs checking?

You know what you, or someone you can name, saw this week. The rest still needs checking, including anything several people have told you if they all heard it from the same person. Write each line with where it came from and the date. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly, so Dad's own account goes down first. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** what Dad says and what the schedule says don't line up and you can't tell why. Bring both, as written, to his care team or to your care consultant.

5 My sister fills in whenever something is missed. Is that a gap or not?

It's help, and it belongs on the list. About 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers, according to the Administration for Community Living. Write down what she does, by day, and note anything that is also on the plan as someone else's job. Then ask how she's holding up. The National Institute on Aging notes that a primary caregiver may be hesitant to ask for help or a break. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** she tells you she can't keep doing some part of it. The people planning Dad's care need to hear that, from her if she's willing.

6 Who is supposed to follow up on each gap?

Whoever the family names, in writing. The National Institute on Aging describes sharing care as deciding who will be responsible for which tasks, and the Family Caregiver Alliance suggests ending a family meeting with a written summary of what each person has agreed to. For each open line, write one name and what that person will find out. [5] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the open line is a clinical question, such as anything about Dad's health or his medications. That follow-up is a call to his doctor, nurse or pharmacist, not a family task.

7 How often does a care plan get looked at again?

It depends on the plan, so ask. The CDC suggests updating a care plan every year, or more often if the person has a change in health or medicines. For Medicare home health, the provider and the home health team review the plan of care as often as necessary, but at least once every 60 days. Neither tells you when Dad's own plan was last reviewed. [7] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't find a date on Dad's plan, or don't know when the next review is. Ask whoever wrote it.

8 If we find a gap, should we change something about his care?

Not on the strength of the list. A list of gaps shows where the plan and the week differ. It doesn't say why, or what the right response is. Medicare says a person getting home health care has the right to be involved in decisions about the plan of care, so Dad has a place in that conversation. Bring the list to it. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** anyone is weighing a change to Dad's care, his medications or who provides his help. That is a conversation for his clinicians and your care consultant, with your list on the table.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Dad himself, and it doesn't say whether his care is working. Anything that depends on his health, his medications or his safety needs someone who has assessed him.

Ready for the next step?

The general questions have plain answers now. The ones about Dad himself need his own details, and the care interview is where those get written down: it goes through his daily life area by area, records who covers each part, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Medicare & Home Health Care (CMS Product No. 10969)
3. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
4. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
5. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
7. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan